As for the Liberal Democrat Leadership's emphasis on the need for "proportionality," this appears at first sight to be reasonable. There is a crude but implicit relationship between "proportionality" and "balance" suggesting that what was required of Ward was criticism of *both* sides in the Israel-Palestinian conflict. A good example of this can be seen in a letter written by Alistair Carmichael to David Ward in July 2013, where he states:

> The Liberal Democrats have regularly and vocally expressed criticism of Israel's actions in the West Bank and Gaza, just as we have condemned terrorist attacks conducted against Israel. For instance, we have condemned Israeli settlement-building for making it even harder to reach a negotiated solution. Similarly we have condemned Hamas for allowing rocket attacks on Israeli civilians from the Gaza Strip.[25]

But although conceptually reasonable, the problem with the "proportionality" requirement is that *in practice* it becomes unreasonable because of the likelihood of its misuse by those politicians who would demonise Israel. This is because of certain powerful trends in Britain today, which help shape the political agenda.

One powerful trend is to regard the "fight for Palestine" as an affirmation of progressive political values.[26] According to Anthony Julius, prominent lawyer and antisemitism scholar, this struggle has replaced the "fight for socialism" as a self-standing cause, unrelated to any larger project of human liberation, and even unrelated to any particular politics.[27] Every act and statement that is hostile to Israel is viewed in a positive light because the Israel-Palestinian conflict is regarded as inherently disproportionate and asymmetrical, with all the force and none of the justice on Israel's side and all the justice but none of the force on the Palestinian side.[28]

Another powerful trend is to be found among many, but by no means all, British Muslims. The 2006 *Parliamentary Report* heard evidence that the Israel-Palestinian conflict has fuelled a sense of anger and injustice among many in the British Muslim community, creating a climate that is more hospitable to radical Islamist ideology, which calls for Israel's destruction.[29] For those sympathetic to this world-view, the Israel-Palestinian conflict is inherently disproportionate.

Several MPs either share these opinions themselves or are influenced by the fact that they serve large electorates that hold—or are assumed to hold—these views. Specifically, while some British Muslims may not have a strong view on the Israel-Palestinian conflict, it appears that MPs think they do and believe that the electoral impact of Gaza cannot be underestimated. For instance, during Operation Protective Edge, Conservative MPs fighting to hold marginal seats with significant Muslim populations were among those urging

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,